

Daily Life in China

Essential Apps Every Foreigner Needs in China

(2026)

CDISCOVERY

<https://cdiscovery-community.netlify.app/>

Essential Apps Every Foreigner Needs in China (2026)

Living in China requires specific apps that most foreigners aren't familiar with. Here's your essential app guide.

Communication & Social:

- * WeChat (微信)

- * -- The #1 essential app. Messaging, payments, mini-programs, social media, government services. 1.3 billion users. Set up immediately upon arrival.

- * Weibo (微博)

- * -- China's Twitter. Follow news, celebrities, trending topics.

Payments:

- * Alipay (支付宝)

* -- Second major payment platform. Also used for utility bills, insurance, investments.

* Note: International credit cards can now be linked to WeChat Pay and Alipay for tourists.

Transportation:

* Didi (滴滴)

* -- China's Uber. Ride-hailing, taxi, and carpooling.

* Amap/Gaode (高德地图)

* -- Best navigation app in China (Google Maps doesn't work well).

* 12306

* -- Official train ticket booking app.

* Trip.com (携程)

* -- Hotels, flights, trains, attractions. English support.

Food & Delivery:

- * Meituan (美团)

- * -- Food delivery, hotel booking, movie tickets, local services.

- * Ele.me (饿了么)

- * -- Food delivery competitor. Often has different restaurant options.

- * Dianping (大众点评)

- * -- Restaurant reviews and ratings (like Yelp).

Shopping:

- * Taobao (淘宝)

- * -- China's Amazon. Everything imaginable, often at very low prices.

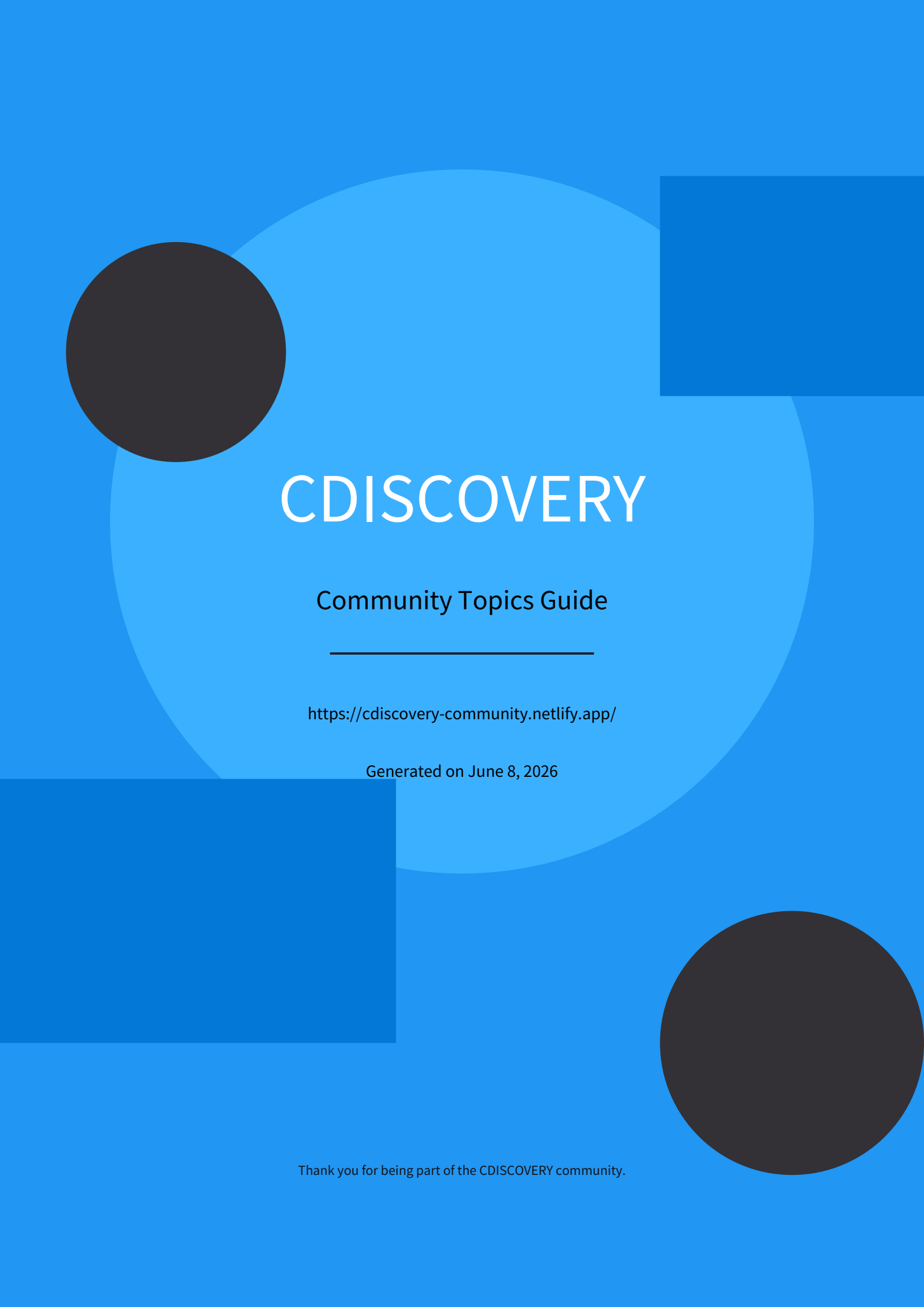
- * JD.com (京东)

- * -- Quality-focused e-commerce with fast delivery.

- * Pinduoduo (拼多多)

* -- Group-buying deals, very affordable.

Sources: Sources: [Government Services Portal](https://www.gov.cn) • [National Health Commission](http://www.nhc.gov.cn)

The background is a solid blue color. In the center, there is a large, light blue circle. To the left of this circle is a dark grey circle. To the right is a dark blue rectangle. Below the light blue circle is a dark blue rectangle. In the bottom right corner is a dark grey circle. The text "CDISCOVERY" is written in white, bold, sans-serif font across the center of the light blue circle.

CDISCOVERY

Community Topics Guide

<https://cdiscovery-community.netlify.app/>

Generated on June 8, 2026

Thank you for being part of the CDISCOVERY community.